by the preceding Indian government, for example, leading to the establishment of the international Nalanda University, together with Singapore and other Asian states, in 2010.

India's Buddhist diplomacy has been developing in collaboration with various Asian countries but also in implicit competition with China, whose soft power strategy has made use of Buddhism as well. P. Stobdan consequentially refers to a geopolitical "great game" being played out in the Buddhist Himalayas between India, China, and Tibet.[39] Reflecting prevalent views in New Delhi, he has observed elsewhere that the Chinese Belt and Road Initiative pursues a narrative centred around a "political geography of Buddhism" that links Myanmar, Nepal, and even Pakistan.[40]

Beyond South Asia and the immediate periphery, India has also explored the religious angle in its efforts to balance China further away, in East Asia. During Modi's visit to Japan in 2014, both countries agreed to a twinning initiative between the holy Hindu city of Benares and Kyoto, Japan's prime Buddhist heritage city, to cooperate in art, culture, and conservation. The 2016 joint statement of the two Prime Ministers emphasised the "deep civilizational links between the people of the two countries."[41] During the first-ever visit of an Indian Prime Minister to Mongolia, in 2015, Narendra Modi presented a sapling of the sacred Bodhi tree and agreed to provide Mongolia with a Buddha statue to symbolise the "spiritual bonding between the people of the two countries."[42]

While Buddhism has been evoked to deepen relations mainly towards the East, often in parallel to similar efforts relating to Hinduism, the Indian government has also used other religions to signal its pluralist soft power. For example, it has been emphasising the relevance of Sufi thought and philosophy to strengthen links towards the West. Sufism is a mystic manifestation and eclectic approach to the core tenets of Islam, which is why it has often been deemed